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## Work, play and learning in a Kpelle town

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Play and Patterns of Thinking and Learning

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A key phrase in Gibb's description is "the instrumental manipulation of others to one's own advantage." Men can and do get ahead by exploiting others especially those with less "sense." To do this one must be clever. In the story reported in Appendix D.<sup>A</sup> Sali is clever and not only escapes the leopard's wrath, but avoids paying his debt as well. Loma, on the other hand is stupid; he charitably rescues leopard only to be eaten. There are innumerable ways one can outwit another person in Gbarngasuakwelle. Even though one may be guilty of adultery one can bribe the diviner and appear innocent, or if one is found guilty one can reduce the penalty to a pittance. In buying and selling, there is no fixed price, bargaining is the rule, and this includes bride-price negotiations. Successful traders are referred to as being clever or as having plenty of sense. Mandingo traders, even if financially successful do not earn esteem for their wealth, however. The reason for this is that they are perhaps "too clever"! they over-exploit their advantage by forming monopolies to drive the price of things they buy down or up on things they sell. They insult their clients and beat them so badly that they don't come back again unless out of dire necessity.

181  
Ethos

437  
Exchange  
Transactions

439  
External Trade

539  
Literary Texts

557  
Manipulative Mobility

563  
Ethnic Stratification

571  
Social Relationships  
And Groups

684  
Sex And Marital  
Offenses

696  
Execution Of Justice

Stone-magic (see page 195) pits a "clever" player against an unwitting audience. The player is usually an older boy and the audience younger boys and I often saw a younger boy "beg" the older boy to teach him the "secret." (This also  290 happened with Bambé.) The older boy would at first refuse, then vacillate and finally agree but, at a price. Competition is inherent in many games, as well, and young boys are fiercely competitive in many of their interactions whether in play, in conversation (joking, teasing, abusing) and in work. This cleverness and competitiveness must however be tempered with caution and prudence, because "no one goes too far in the means he uses to acquire position." And this is where the many "pay attention" games (see page 189) become important. We would visit Yeleke, one of my principal informants, often. He would usually be in conversation with other men when we arrived. He would always greet us warmly, but we learned that when he lowered his eyes this was a signal that the conversation we'd interrupted was serious or private and we would quickly say goodbye. At other times he would keep his eyes on us as we talked and this signaled that the interview session could continue.

124  
Interviewing In  
Research

181  
Ethos

201  
Gestures And Signs

524  
Games

571  
Social Relationships  
And Groups

A, [Apparently Appendix E is intended here. See Category 539, p. 411—Analyst]

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